SF TREE REMOVAL
FAST • SAFE • PROFESSIONAL

Hurricane Tree Checklist

For South Florida homeowners · Miami-Dade, Broward, Palm Beach

Hurricane season runs June 1 to November 30. Most storm damage starts with a tree that was already weak: dead limbs, a split trunk, decay or lifted roots. Use this checklist before, during and after a storm.

1. Before the season

January to May

- [ ] Walk the property and list trees near the house, pool, fence, driveway and power lines.
- [ ] Look for warning signs: dead or brown limbs, cracks or splits, a new lean, lifted soil, mushrooms or decay at the base.
- [ ] Have large or doubtful trees assessed by an ISA certified arborist.
- [ ] Prune dead and weak limbs. Ask for structural pruning, not topping.
- [ ] Palms: remove dead fronds, seed pods and coconuts.
- [ ] Check permit rules for your city and any HOA approval before cutting.
- [ ] Take dated photos of your trees and property.
- [ ] Review your insurance: deductible, tree and debris coverage. Keep the policy handy.

Avoid topping and “hurricane cuts”. University of Florida research shows topping and heavy thinning make trees weaker, not stronger, and topped trees decay and break more easily.

2. When a storm is approaching

72 to 24 hours

- [ ] Do not start major cutting now: crews are busy and loose debris becomes a missile in wind.
- [ ] Pick up coconuts, fruit and loose branches. Move cars from under trees.
- [ ] Photograph the property and trees for your records.
- [ ] Keep your insurance documents, phone numbers and a charged phone together.
- [ ] Know who you will call: your utility, your city and your insurer.
- [ ] Leave trees touching power lines alone. Only the utility handles them.

3. After the storm

- [ ] Make sure everyone is safe. If anyone is in danger, call 911.
- [ ] Assume every downed power line is live. Stay far away and call the utility.
- [ ] Photograph the damage from several angles before anything is moved.
- [ ] Do not stand under hanging limbs or cut a tree that is under tension or on a structure.
- [ ] Cover roof damage to stop water getting in. Keep every receipt.
- [ ] Call your insurer early and ask what they need.
- [ ] Check your city's rules for debris pickup and emergency tree removal.
- [ ] Re-check trees that look fine: hidden cracks and root damage can show up later.

Beware of storm chasers. Crews that go door to door after a storm often ask for cash up front. Ask for proof of license and insurance and get the scope and price in writing.

4. Questions to ask any tree company

- [ ] Can I see proof of license and insurance, in writing?
- [ ] What exactly is included: removal, stump grinding, cleanup, haul-away?
- [ ] How will a big tree near my house, pool or lines come down?
- [ ] Who handles any permit, and is it in the price?
- [ ] What are the payment terms? (Be wary of full payment in advance.)
- [ ] When can you start, and how long will it take?

5. Useful numbers and links

Emergency	911 (danger to life, fires, downed lines)
Power company	In most of South Florida, FPL: 1-800-468-8243 to report outages and downed lines
Before digging	Sunshine 811 (call 811) to mark underground utilities
Permit rules	sftreeremoval.com/permit-checker
Free estimate	sftreeremoval.com/contact-us
Emergency request	sftreeremoval.com/emergency-tree-removal

General information, not professional or legal advice. Rules and phone numbers change; confirm with your city, county or utility. SF Tree Removal is an online service that connects property owners with independent local tree care professionals; it does not perform tree work. Sources include University of Florida IFAS Extension and Florida Statute 163.045. © 2026 SF Tree Removal · sftreeremoval.com